

The screen errored blinking "ERROR" The sweat of being caught out rivuleted down her spine, she was hot as hell and cold as ice at the same time. Trembling, she looked at the punch-cards, trying to decipher how to fill it in properly. It was supposed to be a breeze, Tako had said. He'd probably never had to fill in one of those awful things. A voice in her ear said, "allow me, may I?" a soft creaky voice like an old vinyl recording of a nineteen-sixties violin concert - Beethoven. Dora looked up in fear and desperation. It was the kind visage of Raymond, neighbour, boomer extraordinaire. "A renewal is it?" he muttered, and shuffled the half a dozen /stack of punchcards. "12c is the one we want," he said, and crossed out a number of the lozenges, as well as adding a bunch on the side. "and now for the tricky bit, he said, and procured a bit of sellotape stuck on his visacard. He used a plastic wiggler and deftly covered three lozenges in the middle somewhere. "There, that should foil the cross-checking of "12B with that of your birth certificate." Let me peruse the others... yes, looks alright, let's check 5... here we go, skip the subroutine here," and he sellotaped some more. "Just have a look around to see we're not being Eagled..." Dora peeked over the consoles to the counters where the civil servants were processing the vast stacks of punch-cards. One man which had a big overcoat, was whining petulantly, you could hear him over the whirring of the clunking machines and the punching and the sneezing and shuffling. Other Eagles looked over at his counter, disturbed. Suddenly his large overcoat bulged and out sprung a little jockey dog, a Jack Russel by the looks of it. Yapping loudly it whizzed around the counter, its owner in full pursuit, coattails flapping, whining and yelling, the citizens were dashing away, afraid to get caught up in the hullabaloo. "Now's our change, said Raymond, and entered the forms one by one, the screen giving a "CLEARED" and spitting out a receipt at the end, a tickertape punched free in a riotously optimistic yellow. "Go get your visapass, Dora, now, and he gave her his docket. "counter 5, go!" and the boomer pushed her in the small of her back so that she almost fell over. she stumbled to the counter and slid the two emblems of her freedom under the plexiglass shield. "Here you are ma'am," a request is authorised." She glanced into the chaos of the running dog who was having the time of its life slaloming around the security guards. She noticed Raymond was egging on the dog even more. The civil servant was clearly agitated, and when the new visapass was spat out she didn't give Dora any scrutinous look. She whisked it away, turned and saw security had bodyslammed the dog owner and it looked like they had chucked a blanket over the little dog, who was now all caught up in it and disorientated. Dora slunk off giving it all a wide berth. She noticed Raymond extricating himself elegantly and unobtrusively from the mess. Just as they exited the hall into the cold and windy outdoors, exacerbated by the narrow street two large navy blue trucks screeched to a halt and out came a bunch of guys with computers.